

'In the grate—nearly burnt, but not quite. Queer; looks as though it had been chewed by a dog.'

'It might possibly be Miss Wade's,' suggested Jimmy. 'She has several dogs.' The Superintendent shook his head.

'This isn't a lady's glove—no, not even the large kind of loose glove ladies wear nowadays. Fit it on, sir, a moment.'

He adjusted the blackened object over Jimmy's hand.

'You see—it's large even for you.'

'Do you attach importance to this discovery?' inquired Sir Oswald coldly.

'You never know, Sir Oswald, what's going to be important or what isn't.'

There was a sharp tap at the door and Bundle entered.

'I'm so sorry,' she said apologetically, 'but Father has just rung up. He says I must come home because everybody is worrying him.'

She paused.

'Yes, my dear Eileen,' said George encouragingly, perceiving that there was more to come.

'I wouldn't have interrupted you—only that I thought it might perhaps have something to do with all this. You see, what has upset Father is that one of our footmen is missing. He went out last night and hasn't come back.'

'What is the man's name?' It was Sir Oswald who took up the cross-examination.

'John Bauer.'

'An Englishman?'

'I believe he calls himself a Swiss—but I think he's a German. He speaks English perfectly, though.'

'Ah!' Sir Oswald drew in his breath with a long, satisfied hiss. 'And he has been at Chimneys—how long?'

'Just under a month.'

Sir Oswald turned to the other two.

'Here is our missing man. You know, Lomax, as well as I do, that several foreign Governments are after the thing. I remember the man now perfectly—tall, well-drilled fellow. Came about a fortnight before we left. A clever move. Any new servants here would be closely scrutinized, but at Chimneys, five miles away—' He did not finish the sentence.

'You think the plan was laid so long beforehand?'

'Why not? There are millions in that formula, Lomax. Doubtless Bauer hoped to get access to my private papers at Chimneys, and to learn something of forthcoming arrangements from them. It seems likely that he may have had an accomplice in this house—someone who put him wise to the lie of the land and who saw to the doping of O'Rourke. But Bauer was the man Miss Wade saw climbing down the ivy—the big, powerful man.'

He turned to Superintendent Battle.

'Bauer was your man, Superintendent. And, somehow or other, you let him slip through your fingers.'

'Nonsense, Superintendent. What you are suggesting is impossible.'

'Not at all impossible, sir. He'd done it once. He could do it twice.'

'I don't mean impossible in that sense. But if the man wanted to escape, he'd never bolt back into the house.'

'Safest place for him, Mr Lomax.'

'But Mr O'Rourke's door was still locked on the inside when we came to him.'

'And how did you get to him? Through Sir Stanley's room. That's the way our man went. Lady Eileen tells me she saw the door knob of Mr O'Rourke's door move. That was when our friend was up there the first time. I suspect the key was under Mr O'Rourke's pillow. But his exit is clear enough the second time—through the communicating door and through Sir Stanley's room, which, of course, was empty. Like everyone else, Sir Stanley is rushing downstairs to the library. Our man's got a clear course.'

'And where did he go then?'

Superintendent Battle shrugged his burly shoulders and became evasive.

'Plenty of ways open. Into an empty room on the other side of the house and down the ivy again—out through a side door—or, just possibly, if it was an inside job, he—well, stayed in the house.'

George looked at him in shocked surprise.

'Really, Battle, I should—I should feel it very deeply if one of my servants—er—I have the most perfect reliance on them—it would distress me very much to have to suspect—'

'Nobody's asking you to suspect anyone, Mr Lomax. I'm just putting all the possibilities before you. The servants may be all right—probably are.'

'You have disturbed me,' said George. 'You have disturbed me greatly.'

His eyes appeared more protuberant than ever.

To distract him, Jimmy poked delicately at a curious blackened object on the table.

'What's this?' he asked.

'That's exhibit Z,' said Battle. 'The last of our little lot. It is, or rather it has been, a glove.'

He picked it up, the charred relic, and manipulated it with pride.

'Where did you find it?' asked Sir Oswald.

Battle jerked his head over his shoulder.

Was it his fancy, or did Sir Oswald hesitate for a moment before replying. 'Yes.'

'In your pumps too,' said Lady Coote, 'instead of putting thick shoes on. What would you do without me to look after you?'

She shook her head sadly.

'I think, Maria, if you don't mind leaving us—we have still a lot to discuss.'

'I know, dear, I'm just going.'

Lady Coote withdrew, carrying the empty medicine glass as though it were a goblet out of which she had just administered a death potion.

'Well, Bartle,' said George Lomax, 'it all seems clear enough. Yes, perfectly clear. The man fires a shot, disabling Mr Thesiger, flings away the weapon, runs along the terrace and down the gravel path.'

'Where he ought to have been caught by my men,' put in Bartle.

'Your men, if I may say so, Bartle, seem to have been singularly remiss. They didn't see Miss Wade come in. If they could miss her coming in, they could easily miss the thief going out.'

Superintendent Bartle opened his mouth to speak, then seemed to think better of it. Jimmy Thesiger looked at him curiously. He would have given a lot to know just what was in Superintendent Bartle's mind.

'Must have been a champion runner,' was all the Scotland Yard man contented himself with saying.

'How do you mean, Bartle?'

'Just what I say, Mr Lomax. I was round the corner of the terrace myself not fifty seconds after the shot was fired. And for a man to run all that distance towards me and get round the corner of the path before I appeared round the side of the house—well, as I say, he must have been a champion runner.'

'I am at a loss to understand you, Bartle. You have some idea of your own which I have not yet—er—grasped. You say the man did not go across the lawn and now you hint—What exactly do you hint? That the man did not go down the path? Then in your opinion—er—where *did* he go?'

For answer, Superintendent Bartle jerked an eloquent thumb upwards.

'Eh?' said George.

The Superintendent jerked harder than ever. George raised his head and looked at the ceiling.

'Up there,' said Bartle. 'Up the ivy again.'

Chapter XXIV

Bundle Wonders

HERE was no doubt that Superintendent Bartle was taken aback. He fingered his chin thoughtfully.

'Sir Oswald is right, Bartle,' said George. 'This is the man. Any hope of catching him?'

'There may be, sir. It certainly looks—well, suspicious. Of course the man may turn up again—at Chimneys, I mean.'

'Do you think it likely?'

'No, it isn't,' confessed Bartle. 'Yes, it certainly looks as though Bauer were the man. But I can't quite see how he got in and out of these grounds unobserved.'

'I have already told you my opinion of the men you posted,' said George. 'Hopelessly inefficient—I don't want to blame you, Superintendent, but—' His pause was eloquent.

'Ah, well,' said Bartle lightly, 'my shoulders are broad.'

He shook his head and sighed.

'I must get to the telephone at once. Excuse me, gentlemen. I'm sorry, Mr Lomax—I feel I've rather bungled this business. But it's been puzzling, more puzzling than you know.'

He strode hurriedly from the room.

'Come into the garden,' said Bundle to Jimmy. 'I want to talk to you.'

They went out together through the window. Jimmy stared down at the lawn, frowning.

'What's the matter?' asked Bundle.

Jimmy explained the circumstances of the pistol throwing.

'I'm wondering,' he ended, 'what was in old Battle's mind when he got Coote to throw the pistol. Something, I'll swear. Anyhow, it landed up about ten yards farther than it should have done. You know, Bundle, Battle's a deep one.'

'He's an extraordinary man,' said Bundle. 'I want to tell you about last night.'

She retailed her conversation with the Superintendent. Jimmy listened attentively.

'So the Countess is № 1,' he said thoughtfully. 'It all hangs together very well. № 2—Bauer—comes over from Chimneys. He climbs up into O'Rourke's room, knowing that O'Rourke has had a sleeping draught administered to him—by the Countess somehow or other. The arrangement is that he is to throw down the papers to the Countess, who will be waiting below. Then she'll nip back through the library and up to her room. If Bauer's caught leaving the grounds, they'll find nothing on him. Yes, it was a good plan—but it went wrong. No sooner is the Countess in the library than she hears me coming and has to jump behind the screen. Jolly awkward for her, because she can't warn her accomplice. № 2 pinches the papers, looks out of the window, sees, as he thinks, the Countess waiting, pitches the papers down to her and proceeds to climb down the ivy, where he finds a nasty surprise in the shape of me waiting for him. Pretty nerry work for the Countess waiting behind her screen. All things considered, she told a pretty good story. Yes, it all hangs together very well.'

'Too well,' said Bundle decidedly.

'Eh?' said Jimmy, surprised.

'What about № 7—№ 7, who never appears, but lives in the background. The Countess and Bauer? No, it's not so simple as that. Bauer was here last night, yes. But he was only here in case things went wrong—as they have done. His part is the part of scapegoat; to draw all attention from № 7—the boss.'

'I say, Bundle,' said Jimmy anxiously, 'you haven't been reading too much sensational literature, have you?'

Bundle threw him a glance of dignified reproach.

'Well,' said Jimmy, 'I'm not yet like the Red Queen. I can't believe six impossible things before breakfast.'

'It's after breakfast,' said Bundle.

'Ah, yes, Battle,' broke in George. 'Is it—er—strictly relevant?'

'Perhaps not, Mr Lomax. But we like to get things just so, you know. I wonder now if one of you gentlemen would take this pistol and throw it. Will you, Sir Oswald? That's very kind. Stand just here in the window. Now fling it into the middle of the lawn.'

Sir Oswald complied, sending the pistol flying through the air with a powerful sweep of his arm. Jimmy Thesiger drew near with breathless interest. The Superintendent lumbered off after it like a well-trained retriever. He reappeared with a beaming face.

'That's it, sir. Just the same kind of mark. Although, by the way, you sent it a good ten yards farther. But then, you're a very powerfully built man, aren't you, Sir Oswald? Excuse me, I thought I heard someone at the door.'

The Superintendent's ears must have been very much sharper than anyone else's. Nobody else had heard a sound, but Battle was proved right, for Lady Coote stood outside, a medicine glass in her hand.

'Your medicine, Oswald,' she said, advancing into the room. 'You forgot it after breakfast.'

'I'm very busy, Maria,' said Sir Oswald. 'I don't want my medicine.'

'You would never take it if it wasn't for me,' said his wife serenely, advancing upon him. 'You're just like a naughty little boy. Drink it up now.'

And meekly, obediently, the great steel magnate drank it up!

Lady Coote smiled sadly and sweetly at everyone.

'Am I interrupting you? Are you very busy? Oh, look at those revolvers.

Nasty, noisy, murdering things. To think, Oswald, that you might have been shot by the burglar last night.'

'You must have been alarmed when you found he was missing, Lady Coote,' said Battle.

'I didn't think of it at first,' confessed Lady Coote. 'This poor boy here—she indicated Jimmy—'being shot—and everything so dreadful, but so exciting. It wasn't till Mr Bateman asked me where Sir Oswald was that I remembered he'd gone out half an hour before for a stroll.'

'Sleepless, eh, Sir Oswald?' asked Battle.

'I am usually an excellent sleeper,' said Sir Oswald. 'But I must confess that last night I felt unusually restless. I thought the night air would do me good.' 'You came out through this window, I suppose?'

'The man who handled it wore gloves,' he said slowly.

'A pity,' said Sir Oswald.

'A man who knew his business would wear gloves. Am I right in thinking, Sir Oswald, that you found this pistol just about twenty yards from the bottom of the steps leading up to the terrace?'

Sir Oswald stepped to the window.

'Yes, almost exactly, I should say.'

'I don't want to find fault, but it would have been wiser on your part, sir, to leave it exactly as you found it.'

'I am sorry,' said Sir Oswald stiffly.

'Oh, it doesn't matter. I've been able to reconstruct things. There were your footprints, you see, leading up from the bottom of the garden, and a place where you had obviously stopped and scooped down, and a kind of dent in the grass which was highly suggestive. By the way, what was your theory of the pistol being there?'

'I presumed that it had been dropped by the man in his flight.'

Battle shook his head.

'Not dropped, Sir Oswald. There are two points against that. To begin with, there is only one set of footprints crossing the lawn just there—your own.'

'I see,' said Sir Oswald thoughtfully.

'Can you be sure of that, Battle?' put in George.

'Quite sure, sir. There is one other set of tracks crossing the lawn, Miss Wade's, but they are a good deal farther to the left.'

He paused, and then went on: 'And there's the dent in the ground. The pistol must have struck the ground with some force. It all points to its having been thrown.'

'Well, why not?' said Sir Oswald. 'Say the man fled down the path to the left. He'd leave no footprints on the path and he'd hurl the pistol away from him into the middle of the lawn, eh, Lomax?'

George agreed by a nod of the head.

'It's true that he'd leave no footprints on the path,' said Battle, 'but from the shape of the dent and the way the turf was cut, I don't think the pistol was thrown from that direction. I think it was thrown from the terrace here.'

'Very likely,' said Sir Oswald. 'Does it matter, Superintendent?'

'Or even after breakfast. We've got a perfectly good hypothesis which fits the facts—and you won't have it at any price, simply because like the old riddle, you want to make things more difficult.'

'I'm sorry,' said Bundle, 'but I cling passionately to a mysterious № 7 being a member of the house-party.'

'What does Bill think?'

'Bill,' said Bundle coldly, 'is impossible.'

'Oh,' said Jimmy. 'I suppose you've told him about the Countess? He ought to be warned. Heaven knows what he'll go blabbing about otherwise.'

'He won't hear a word against her,' said Bundle. 'He's—oh, simply idiotic. I wish you'd drive it home to him about that mole.'

'You forget I wasn't in the cupboard,' said Jimmy. 'And anyway I'd rather not argue with Bill about his lady friend's mole. But surely he can't be such an ass as not to see that everything fits in?'

'He's every kind of ass,' said Bundle bitterly. 'You made the greatest mistake, Jimmy, in ever telling him at all.'

'I'm sorry,' said Jimmy. 'I didn't see it at the time—but I do now. I was a fool, but dash it all, old Bill—'

'You know what foreign adventures are,' said Bundle. 'How they get hold of one.'

'As a matter of fact, I don't,' said Jimmy. 'One has never tried to get hold of me.' And he sighed.

For a moment or two there was silence. Jimmy was turning things over in his mind. The more he thought about them, the more unsatisfactory they seemed.

'You say that Battle wants the Countess let alone,' he said at last.

'Yes.'

'The idea being that through her he will get at someone else?'

Bundle nodded.

Jimmy frowned deeply as he tried to see where this led. Clearly Battle had some very definite idea in his mind.

'Sir Stanley Digby went up to town early this morning, didn't he?' he said.

'Yes.'

'O'Rourke with him?'

'Yes, I think so.'

'You don't think—no, that's impossible?'

'What?'

'That O'Rourke can be mixed up in this in any way?'

'It's possible,' said Bundle thoughtfully. 'He's got what one calls a very vivid personality. No, it wouldn't surprise me if—oh, to tell the truth, nothing would surprise me! In fact, there's only one person I'm really sure isn't № 7?'

'Who's that?'

'Superintendent Battle.'

'Oh! I thought you were going to say George Lomax.'

'Ssh, here he comes.'

George was, indeed, bearing down upon them in an unmistakable manner. Jimmy made an excuse and slipped away. George sat down by Bundle.

'My dear Eileen, must you really leave us?'

'Well, Father seems to have got the wind up rather badly. I think I'd better go home and hold his hand.'

'This little hand will indeed be comforting,' said George, taking it and pressing it playfully. 'My dear Eileen, I understand your reasons and I honour you for them. In these days of changed and unsettled conditions—'

'He's off,' thought Bundle desperately.

'—when family life is at a premium—all the old standards falling!—it becomes our class to set an example—to show that we, at least, are unaffected by modern conditions. They call us the Die Hards—I am proud of the term—I repeat I am proud of the term! There are things that *should* die hard—dignity, beauty, modesty, the sanctity of family life, filial respect—who dies if these shall live? As I was saying, my dear Eileen, I envy you the privileges of your youth. Youth! What a wonderful thing! What a wonderful word! And we do not appreciate it until we grow to—er—mature years. I confess, my dear child, that I have in the past been disappointed by your levity. I see now it was but the careless and charming levity of a child. I perceive now the serious and earnest beauty of your mind. You will allow me, I hope, to help you with your reading?'

'Oh, thank you,' said Bundle faintly.

'And you must never be afraid of me again. I was shocked when Lady Carerham told me that you stood in awe of me. I can assure you that I am a very humdrum sort of person.'

Chapter XXIII

Superintendent Battle in Charge

IT was ten o'clock on the following morning. The sun poured in through the windows of the library, where Superintendent Battle had been at work since six. On a summons from him, George Lomax, Sir Oswald Coote and Jimmy Thesiger had just joined him, having repaired the fatigues of the night with a substantial breakfast. Jimmy's arm was in a sling, but he bore little other trace of the night's affray.

The Superintendent eyed all three of them benevolently, somewhat with the air of a kindly curator explaining a museum to little boys. On the table beside him were various objects, neatly labelled. Amongst them Jimmy recognized Leopold.

'Ah, Superintendent,' said George, 'I have been anxious to know how you have progressed. Have you caught the man?'

'He'll take a lot of catching,' he will,' said the Superintendent easily.

His failure in that respect did not appear to rankle with him.

George Lomax did not look particularly well pleased. He detested levity of any kind.

'I've got everything taped out pretty clearly,' went on the detective.

He took up two objects from the table.

'Here we've got the two bullets. The largest is a .455, fired from Mr Thesiger's Colt automatic. Grazed the window sash and I found it embedded in the trunk of that cedar tree. This little fellow was fired from the Mauser .25. After passing through Mr Thesiger's arm, it embedded itself in this arm-chair here. As for the pistol itself—'

'Well?' said Sir Oswald eagerly. 'Any fingerprints?'

Battle shook his head.

‘But what was she doing there anyway? One doesn’t come down to look for a book with an electric torch.’

Battle scratched his cheek. He seemed unwilling to speak. He began to pace up and down the room, as though making up his mind. At last he turned to the girl.

‘See here, Lady Eileen, I’m going to trust you. The Countess’s conduct is suspicious. I know that as well as you do. It’s very suspicious—but we’ve got to go carefully. There mustn’t be any unpleasantness with the Embassies. One has got to be *sure*.’

‘I see. If you were *sure*...’

‘There’s something else. During the war, Lady Eileen, there was a great outcry about German spies being left at large. Busybodies wrote letters to the papers about it. We paid no attention. Hard words didn’t hurt us. The small fry were left alone. Why? Because through them, sooner or later, *we got the big fellow—the man at the top*.’

‘You mean?’

‘Don’t bother about what I mean, Lady Eileen. But remember this. *I know all about the Countess*. And I want her let alone.’

And now,’ added Superintendent Battle ruefully, ‘I’ve got to think of something to say to Sir Stanley Digby!’

The spectacle of George being modest struck Bundle spellbound. George continued.

‘Never be shy with me, dear child. And do not be afraid of boring me. It will be a great delight to me to—if I may say so—form your budding mind. I will be your political mentor. We have never needed young women of talent and charm in the Party more than we need them to-day. You may well be destined to follow in the footsteps of your aunt, Lady Caterham.’

This awful prospect knocked Bundle out completely. She could only stare helplessly at George. This did not discourage him—on the contrary. His main objection to women was that they talked too much. It was seldom that he found what he considered a really good listener. He smiled benignantly at Bundle.

‘The butterfly emerging from the chrysalis. A wonderful picture. I have a very interesting work on political economy; I will look it out now, and you can take it to Chimneys with you. When you have finished it, I will discuss it with you. Do not hesitate to write to me if any point puzzles you. I have many public duties, but by unsparing work I can always make time for the affairs of my friends. I will look for the book.’

He strode away. Bundle gazed after him with a dazed expression. She was roused by the unexpected advent of Bill.

‘Look here,’ said Bill, ‘what the hell was Codders holding your hand for?’

‘It wasn’t my hand,’ said Bundle wildly. ‘It was my budding mind.’

‘Don’t be an ass, Bundle.’

‘Sorry, Bill, but I’m a little worried. Do you remember saying that Jimmy ran a grave risk coming down here?’

‘So he does,’ said Bill. ‘It’s frightfully hard to escape from Codders once he’s got interested in you. Jimmy will be caught in the toils before he knows where he is.’

‘It’s not Jimmy who’s got caught—it’s me,’ said Bundle wildly. ‘I shall have to meet endless Mrs Macatras, and read political economy and discuss it with George, and heavens knows where it will end!’

Bill whistled.

‘Poor old Bundle. Been laying it on a bit thick, haven’t you?’

‘I must have done. Bill, I feel horribly entangled.’

'Never mind,' said Bill consolingly. 'George doesn't really believe in women standing for Parliament, so you won't have to stand up on platforms and talk a lot of junk, or kiss dirty babies in Bernondsey. Come and have a cocktail. It's nearly lunch time.'

Bundle got up and walked by his side obediently.

'And I do so hate politics,' she murmured piteously.

'Of course you do. So do all sensible people. It's only people like Codders and Pongo who take them seriously and revel in them. But all the same,' said Bill, reverting suddenly to a former point, 'you oughtn't to let Codders hold your hand.'

'Why on earth not?' said Bundle. 'He's known me all my life.'

'Well, I don't like it.'

'Virtuous William—Oh, I say, look at Superintendent Bartle.'

They were just passing in through a side door. A cupboard-like room opened out of the little hallway. In it were kept golf clubs, tennis racquets, bows and other features of country house life. Superintendent Bartle was conducting a minute examination of various golf clubs. He looked up a little sheepishly at Bundle's exclamation.

'Going to take up golf, Superintendent Bartle?'

'I might do worse, Lady Eileen. They say it's never too late to start. And I've got one good quality that will tell at any game.'

'What's that?' asked Bill.

'I don't know when I'm beaten. If everything goes wrong, I turn to and start again.'

And with a determined look on his face, Superintendent Bartle came out and joined them, shutting the door behind him.

As concisely as she could, Bundle related her introduction to the Seven Dials Club and her subsequent adventures there. When she had finished, Superintendent Bartle drew a long breath. For once, his facial woodenness was laid aside.

'Remarkable,' he said. 'Remarkable. I wouldn't have believed it possible—even for you, Lady Eileen. I ought to have known better.'

'But you did give me a hint, Superintendent Bartle. You told me to ask Bill Eversleigh.'

'It's dangerous to give people like you a hint, Lady Eileen. I never dreamt of your going to the lengths you have.'

'Well, it's all right, Superintendent Bartle. My death doesn't lie at your door.'

'Not yet, it doesn't,' said Bartle grimly.

He stood as though in thought, turning things over in his mind.

'What Mr Theisger was about, letting you run into danger like that, I can't think,' he said presently.

'He didn't know till afterwards,' said Bundle. 'I'm not a complete mug, Superintendent Bartle. And anyway, he's got his hands full looking after Miss Wade.'

'Is that so?' said the Superintendent. 'Ah!'

He twinkled a little.

'I shall have to detail Mr Eversleigh to look after you, Lady Eileen.'

'Bill!' said Bundle contemptuously. 'But Superintendent Bartle, you haven't heard the end of my story. The woman I saw there—Anna—No 1. Yes, No 1 is the Countess Radzky.'

And rapidly she went on to describe her recognition of the mole.

To her surprise the Superintendent hemmed and hawed.

'A mole isn't much to go upon, Lady Eileen. Two women might have an identical mole very easily. You must remember that the Countess Radzky is a very well-known figure in Hungary.'

'Then this isn't the real Countess Radzky. I tell you I'm sure this is the same woman I saw there. And look at her to-night—the way we found her. I don't believe she ever fainted at all.'

'Oh, I shouldn't say that, Lady Eileen. That empty shell striking the book-case beside her might have frightened any woman half out of her wits.'